



FITNESSWISE

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The missing variable in endurance performance

Even the most disciplined athletes can **stagnate** — because performance is shaped not just by training load, but by how deeply an athlete engages with the process.

For many years, I believed dedication, determination and discipline were the most important variables in life. It is a simple formula, and in many ways it works, has worked, and will continue to work. Discipline protects the process when determination vacillates. Without discipline, many endurance sports are nearly unfeasible. The body's adaptation is slow, and only progressive and steady work allows those adaptations to accumulate.

But over the years, as an S&C coach, I began noticing something that did not tally with this equation.

Why do some athletes with great discipline hit a wall?

If endurance sport were purely physiological, the equation should be straightforward in the performance domain. But, is it so?

This is a simple, straightforward mantra in training parlance:

Better training = Better adaptation

Better adaptation = Better performance

But athletes are complex human systems involving varied parameters — an open secret to all — where training load or workload monitoring alone cannot be a game changer for peak performance.

The athlete as a system

When something does not behave as expected, I assume there is a missing variable somewhere in the process.

Any process can be simplified into three components:

Input Efforts → Progression → Yields

In theory, if the inputs are correct and the process is

followed long enough, the yields should increase.

But athletes are living, adaptive individuals. Their physiology is influenced by emotions, identity, purpose, curiosity, and other facets of physiological and psychological processes.

Something judicious is missing from the simple, straightforward model.

There is another variable that shapes how training stress is experienced, understood and absorbed.

Let's call it psychological energy, or perhaps more simply: liveliness.

What's amiss?

When athletes stagnate despite good training, the concern is rarely the planning or the programme itself. Often, the sessions are still well designed. The physiology might even be progressing quietly beneath the surface. What begins to shrivel is the athlete's engagement with the process.

The athlete is executing sessions, but not truly partaking in them. From a process perspective, this matters enormously.

Because the effectiveness of